State Review LEARNINGS:

American Board

Alternative

On-Site Review: February 5-6, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

The report uses evidence from both state data collection and an onsite review to examine educator preparation program performance. The information in this report is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

This report rates the EPP on all three Standards of the Arkansas Education Preparation Provider State Review Framework, which are fundamental to support teacher candidates in their journey to becoming successful teachers who meet the needs of students in Arkansas:

- Standard 1, “Candidate Recruitment and Completion,” is rated primarily with quantitative data from state data collection.
- For Standard 2, "Preparing Candidates Effectively," criteria to assess performance resulted from multiple conversations with a group of stakeholders that included teacher preparation program deans, candidates, current school leaders & teachers, recent graduates, and DESE staff.
- The ratings for Standard 3, “Supporting Workforce Needs,” is based on state data reporting.

Performance Levels are defined as follows:

Performance Level	Average Score Equivalent
EXCEEDS	Average score equivalent to exceeds on two of three standards or indicators
MEETS	Average score equivalent to meets on all three standards or indicators
APPROACHING	Average score equivalent to approaching on one standard or indicator and meets on the other two
BELOW	Average score equivalent to below on one standard or indicator and approaching on the other two

American Board

Alternative

Overall Performance Level		
BELOW		
Performance Levels by Standard		
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion	Standard 2: Preparing Candidates Effectively	Standard 3: Supporting Workforce Needs
APPROACHING	BELOW	BELOW

STANDARD 1: RECRUITMENT & COMPLETION

Standard 1 Performance Level		
APPROACHING		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 1.1 Plans	**Indicator 1.2 Recruitment**	**Indicator 1.3 Completion**
MEETS	MEETS	BELOW

Recommendations

American Board's fully virtual, asynchronous, flexible program model and low cost of tuition attract candidates to enroll in its program, particularly in certification shortage areas.

While American Board advertises the program as leading to certification in a year or less, data in Arkansas shows that only 11% of enrollees complete within three years. American Board should focus on identifying the barriers candidates face that are causing them not to complete the program and embed solutions into the program. *(Focus Area: Criteria 1.3a)*

INDICATOR 1.1: PLANS

Criteria 1.1a

Programs have formal plans to meet the targets described in the state review framework (I.e.; Standards 1-3) and show evidence of acting on their plans

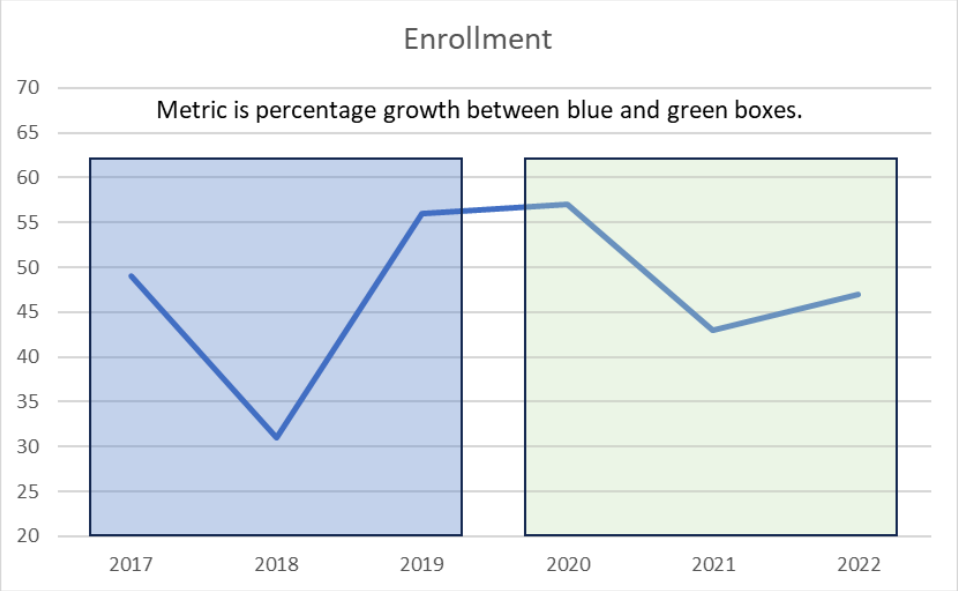
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	EPPs were not asked to submit formal plans to meet the state review framework targets or to show evidence of acting on their plans as part of the Spring 2024 review cycle. As a result, all EPPS in this cycle will receive a rating of MEETS.

INDICATOR 1.2: RECRUITMENT

Criteria 1.2a

Programs meet annual recruitment targets that align with their program size and Arkansas's workforce needs

Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Growth in 3yr Average Enrollment	Performance Level
Percentage growth in 3yr average enrollment	10%	8.1%	MEETS

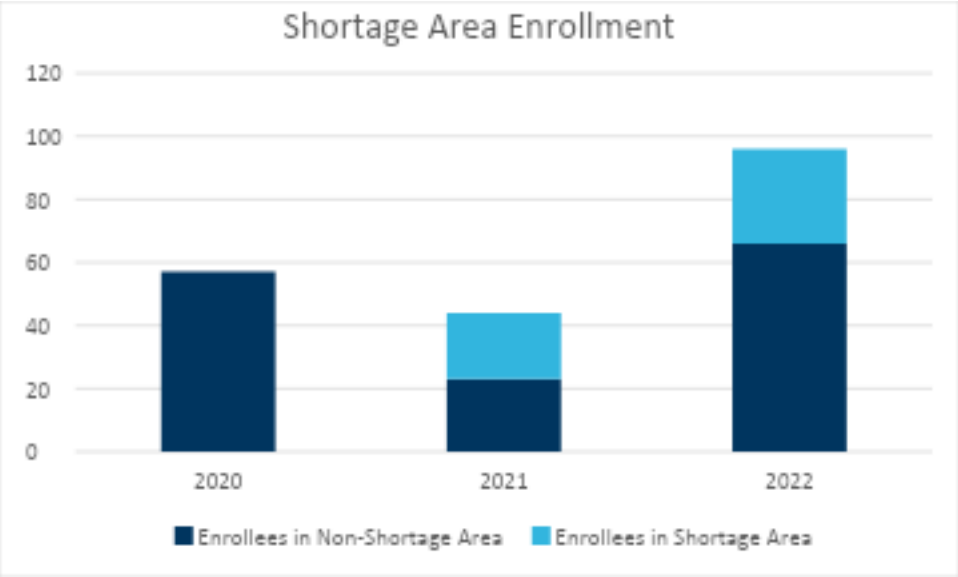


*The enrollment growth target was established with the aim of closing the sizeable gap between EPP completers and those leaving the classroom over the next 10yrs. EPPs can earn a "Meets" rating by demonstrating positive program enrollment growth (i.e., growth greater than zero) and an "Exceeds" rating by demonstrating growth greater than 10 percent.

Criteria 1.2b

Programs recruit candidates for Arkansas certification shortage areas in proportion to the need

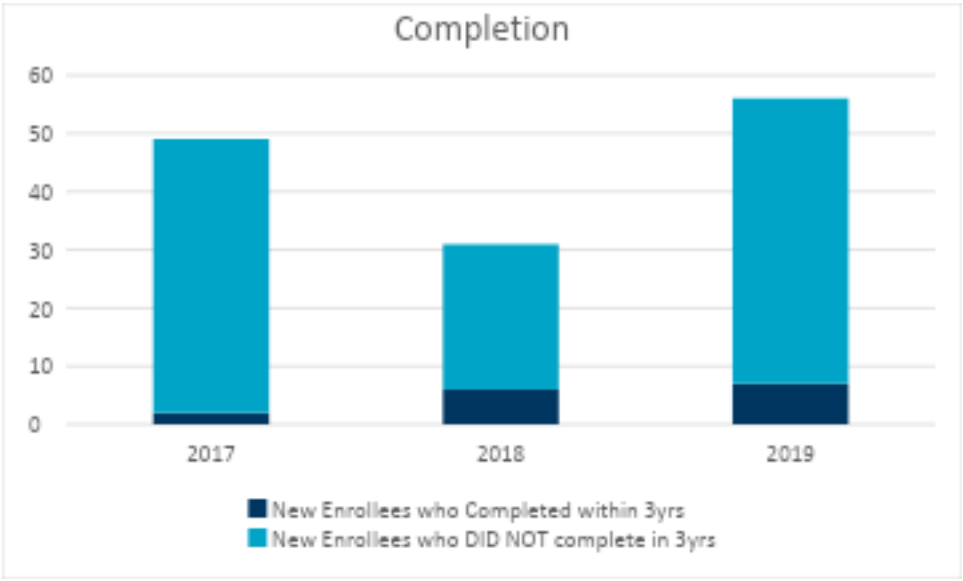
Metric	Target	EPP's Percent of new enrollees in Shortage Areas	Performance Level
Percentage of program candidates recruited in shortage areas	24%	26%	EXCEEDS



*Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline) and demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased) as well as state focus areas. Current licensure areas of shortage: Computer Science (4-12), Biology (7-12), Chemistry (7-12), Physics (7-12), Foreign Language (K-12), Math (7-12), Math (4-8), Science (4-8), Special Education (K-12)

INDICATOR 1.3: COMPLETION

Criteria 1.3a Candidates have high rates of completion			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Completion Rate	Performance Level
Three-year average completion rate	74%	11%	BELOW


Completion
60
50
40
30
20
10
0
2017
2018
2019
New Enrollees who Completed within 3yrs
New Enrollees who DID NOT complete in 3yrs

Standard 2: PREPARING CANDIDATES EFFECTIVELY

Standard 2 Performance Level		
BELOW		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 2.1 Coursework	Indicator 2.2 Clinical Experiences	Indicator 2.3 Development
BELOW	BELOW	BELOW

Recommendations

Flexibility for candidates is a strength of American Board's program model.

Recommendations center around redesigning the American Board program to align with the standards outlined in the Arkansas State Review Framework and Standards Map, including clinical experiences with coaching to ensure participants develop effective teaching skills.

- Audit coursework for content connections, ensuring that all sessions drive towards implementation in participant classrooms and increasing student achievement. Audit coursework for classroom connections, ensuring participants analyze different models and best practices of instruction, such as Arkansas Teaching Standards as observed by the Aspiring Teacher Rubric and TESS. *(Focus Area: Criteria 2.1a, Criteria 2.1b, and Criteria 2.1c)*
- Establish clinical experiences with coaching to ensure participants develop effective teaching skills. *(Focus Area: Criteria 2.2a, Criteria 2.2b, and Criteria 2.2c)*
- Begin preparing now to meet the state's one-year residency requirement that will apply to spring 2027 completers and beyond. Formalize systems and structures to ensure that the mentor teachers and clinical supervisors working with candidates are experienced, very effective and, by the 2026-2027 school year, have received DESE-recognized coaching training. *(Focus Area: Criteria 2.2b, 2.3c Metric 2)*
- Establish goals and metrics around participant attainment of program requirements. Set up processes to gather data to make data-based decisions for continuous programmatic improvement and support struggling candidates who are not meeting goals or attaining program requirements. *(Focus Area: Criteria 2.3a, Criteria 2.3b)*

INDICATOR 2.1: COURSEWORK

Criteria 2.1a

Candidates receive high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based

Performance Level	Explanation
BELOW	Evidence was submitted demonstrating that some nationally recognized best practices around content instruction are incorporated into the coursework. For example, pdfs of sample study plans were submitted in content areas such as mathematics, English, biology, world history, and United States History. However, the full lessons and courses were unavailable for reviewers to see pedagogical best

	practices. The EPP could not answer questions related to the original design and development of the curriculum because it was written before their tenure. There was no reference to HQIM referenced in the evidence. Coursework does not train candidates to use Arkansas K-12 Standards for their licensure area, and it is not evident that Arkansas K-12 standards are utilized to inform curriculum design or support candidate preparedness for the classroom. The word "standards" is incorporated throughout the American Board's documents on the website, study plans, and workbook. However, in the evidence submitted, the EPP does not utilize the Arkansas K-12 standards as a foundation for teacher development in its coursework. In the Program Director Focus group, one participant explained that, as designed, American Board's curriculum is intended to meet the demands of candidates in multiple states. The curriculum does include links to Arkansas state standards, and candidates are told to reference Arkansas standards during their study preparation. No evidence was submitted that coursework provides candidates with opportunities to vertically integrate standards throughout all grade bands within the licensure area.
Criteria 2.1b Candidates' coursework supports their development as a teacher	
BELOW	Courses are not sequenced to build off previous coursework. The EPP does not provide a traditional program of study with coursework presented in sequence with a developmental progression. Instead, American Board requires candidates to complete two programs of study, consisting of self-paced study materials that culminate in comprehensive EPP-designed assessments. In a focus group interview, one participant stated that they recommend students to "progress through pedagogy first, but they do not have to," indicating there is not a specified sequence and progression of courses. Evidence was submitted that Coursework incorporates Arkansas Educator Competencies and Arkansas Teaching Standards in a way that partially develops candidates to meet the competencies of their required licensure area. A crosswalk was submitted as evidence of alignment between Professional Teaching Knowledge (PTK) and InTASC standards. However, neither the crosswalk nor PTK standards have been approved by DESE. The EPP provided a matrix that articulated alignment between the Arkansas Educator Competencies and the American Board's own standards. They did the same for the Arkansas Teacher Standards and American Board's own standards. Additionally, while Plans of Study were submitted that provide an overview of the content of each course, actual coursework was not submitted for review, so it is not possible to understand the extent to which it supports candidates' development as a teacher as articulated by the ATS or Arkansas Educator Competencies. There is no clinical experience and no course instructors, two elements of Arkansas' standards for EPPs to prepare day-one ready teachers.
Criteria 2.1c Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors	
BELOW	As the program has no course instructors, none show deep knowledge of Arkansas K12 standards, content knowledge, and content pedagogy. In the narrative submitted with the evidence, it was stated, "Our candidates are provided with access to study materials that were developed by university professors and field experts through a $45 million grant from the U.S. Department of Education." However, no evidence was provided of their selection or instructor credentials. The EPP does not utilize instructors or course facilitators. Therefore, no evidence was submitted documenting their knowledge and effectiveness. There were no focus groups with teaching candidates, program completers, or data related to student coursework evaluations to gather any additional evidence.

INDICATOR 2.2: CLINICAL EXPERIENCES

Indicator 2.2a Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as a teacher	
Performance Level	**Explanation**
BELOW	American Board does not include clinical experiences within their program. The EPP cites the state-required mentorship as satisfying this metric. Still, Arkansas does not consider this experience to be "clinical" in nature. According to the Arkansas State Review Framework and Standards Map, clinical experiences are provided by the program that supports their development as a teacher. This includes: - The overall sequence of clinical experiences clearly and intentionally builds off previous experiences and includes opportunities for learning and development. - The overall variety of clinical experiences (aligned to the Aspiring Teacher Rubric) provides adequate opportunities for candidates to work with students with varied learning needs. The EPP provides no evidence that their state-required mentorship meets these expectations. Further, American Board does not have partnerships with schools and provides little counseling to teachers about where to teach after completing the program.
Criteria 2.2b Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship	
BELOW	The EPP does not provide candidates with clinical experiences, so no evidence was provided to demonstrate their effectiveness. American Board's state-required mentorship does not meet expectations for an effective experience, as there is no process to select experienced mentor teachers or measure their coaching skills. There is also no evidence that clinical supervisors have a proven history of effective instructional practices and coaching with high-quality feedback.
Criteria 2.2c Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that facilitate the development of strong candidates	
BELOW	American Board does not partner with specific schools or offer clinical experience. American Board did not provide evidence to show collaborative processes between the EPP and districts/schools. There was no evidence of collaborative processes that support or develop effective clinical supervisors.

INDICATOR 2.3: DEVELOPMENT

Criteria 2.3a Candidates are successful with their program coursework	
Performance Level	**Explanation**
BELOW	American Board defines proficiency as the successful completion of each program's exam. However, the State Review team could not determine if candidates showed proficiency in their coursework requirements. The EPP provided the minimum passing scores, means, and ranges of scores on their assessments; however, the number of candidates, completers, test takers, and test

	re-takes was not provided. The data was not disaggregated by year or cohort. The data was not reported at the candidate/completer level, so reviewers could not determine whether individuals or cohort candidates were proficient. American Board does provide candidates with some support if their coursework requirements are not on track. Still, that support is not individualized, and the EPP does not take an active role in creating a plan and monitoring progress. The EPP did provide one example of remedial support by stating that candidates may be directed to additional resources beyond what American Board provides in their coursework (i.e., Khan Academy videos). American Board utilizes a help desk to answer questions, give feedback, and provide tech support. It is not clear what this entails, and data was not provided to ensure that the support given is sufficient to advance candidate success. American Board did not provide evidence that they provide support around pedagogical or content knowledge. American Board did report that candidates may be referred for remediation. Still, support was not described, and data were not provided on the number of candidates needing remediation, how they were identified, remediated, or outcomes.
Criteria 2.3b Candidates are successful in their clinical internship	
BELOW	American Board does not include clinical experiences within their program. The EPP cites the state-required mentorship as satisfying this metric. Still, Arkansas does not consider this experience to be "clinical" in nature. For example, American Board does not have a set of goals and milestones for candidates' mentorship experience. American Board does not directly track candidate impact on student growth, so such evidence was not provided to the State Review team. The Drexel Principal report was cited as evidence, along with teacher retention data. Neither data point presents strong evidence on candidates/completers for the purposes of this State Review as 1) the data is from 2016, 2) the data is not disaggregated by state, 3) the instrument was not designed to provide data for this metric. Similarly, American Board does not track candidates' scores on the Aspiring Teacher Rubric. Therefore, no evidence was submitted that candidates score "effective" on the TESS components or the Aspiring Teacher Rubric.

STANDARD 3: SUPPORTING WORKFORCE NEEDS

Standard 3 Performance Level		
BELOW		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 3.1 Licensure	Indicator 3.2 Employment	Indicator 3.3 Effectiveness
BELOW	BELOW	MEETS

Recommendations

Considering a completer of American Board's program must be employed for three years after completion under a provisional license before being eligible for a standard license, completers are not able to meet licensure and employment targets. Recommendations include:

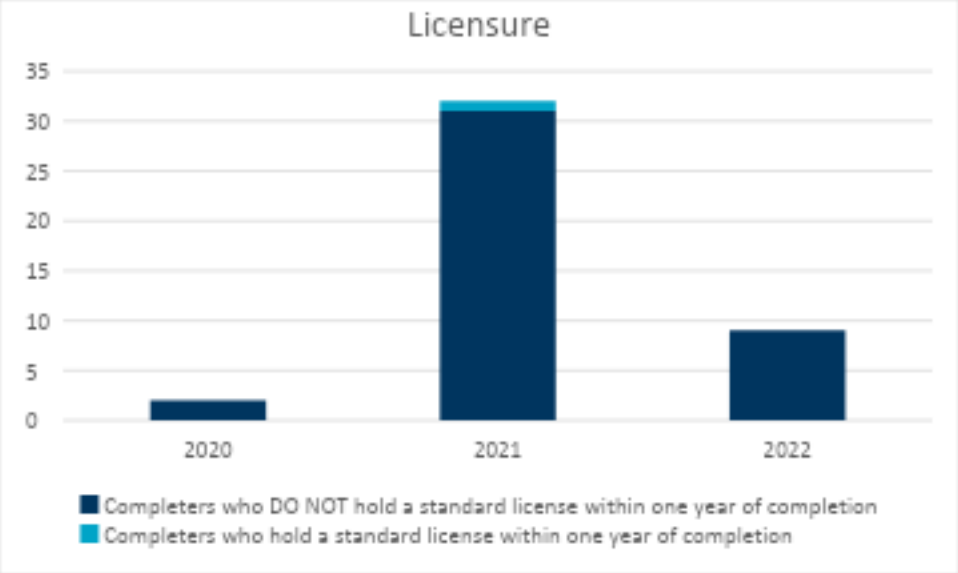
- Redefine definition of program completer; extend a candidates' enrollment years to cover the years that they are under provisional license so that they become eligible for a standard license upon completion. (*Focus Area: Criteria 3.1a-c and 3.2a-c)*
- Analyze EPP Completer Supervisor Survey results to identify specific TESS domains and components in which supervisor's felt American Board completers were least prepared. *(Focus Areas: Criteria 3.3c)*

INDICATOR 3.1: LICENSURE

Criteria 3.1a

A high proportion of program candidates obtain a standard license

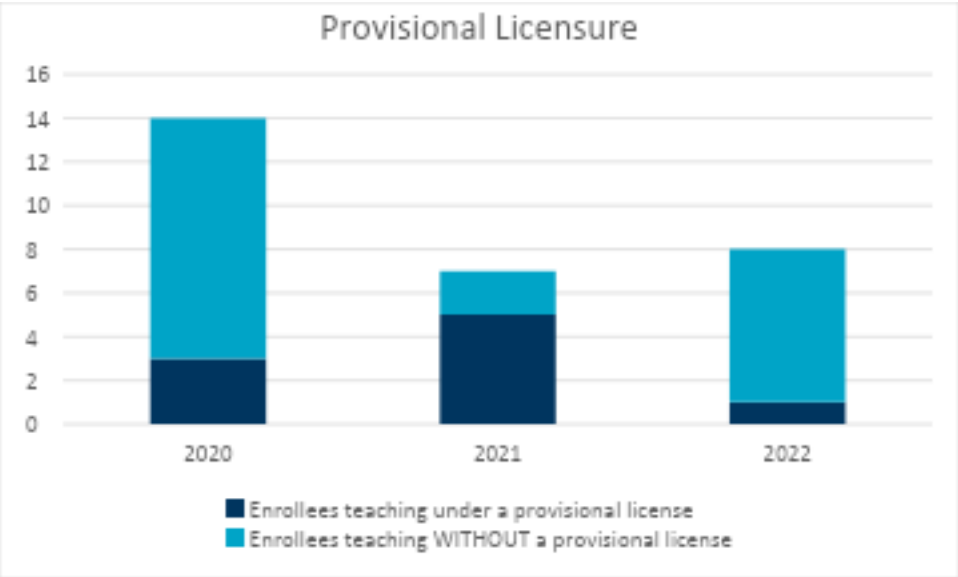
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who have earned a standard license	76%	2%	BELOW



Criteria 3.1b

A high proportion of alternative route enrollees are provisionally licensed

Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of alternative route enrollees who are provisionally licensed	69%	31%	BELOW



Criteria 3.1c

A high proportion of traditional program candidates pass the Praxis content exam in their area on the first try

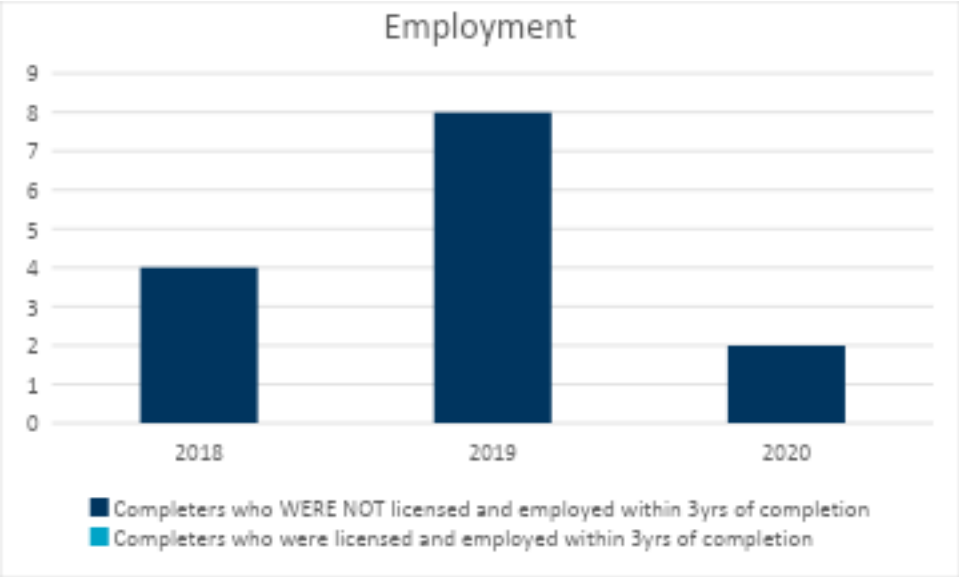
Metric	Target	EPP's First Time Pass Percentage	Performance Level
Percentage of first-time Praxis test takers that pass on their first try	65%	n/a	n/a

INDICATOR 3.2: EMPLOYMENT

Criteria 3.2a

A high proportion of completers are employed in Arkansas public schools

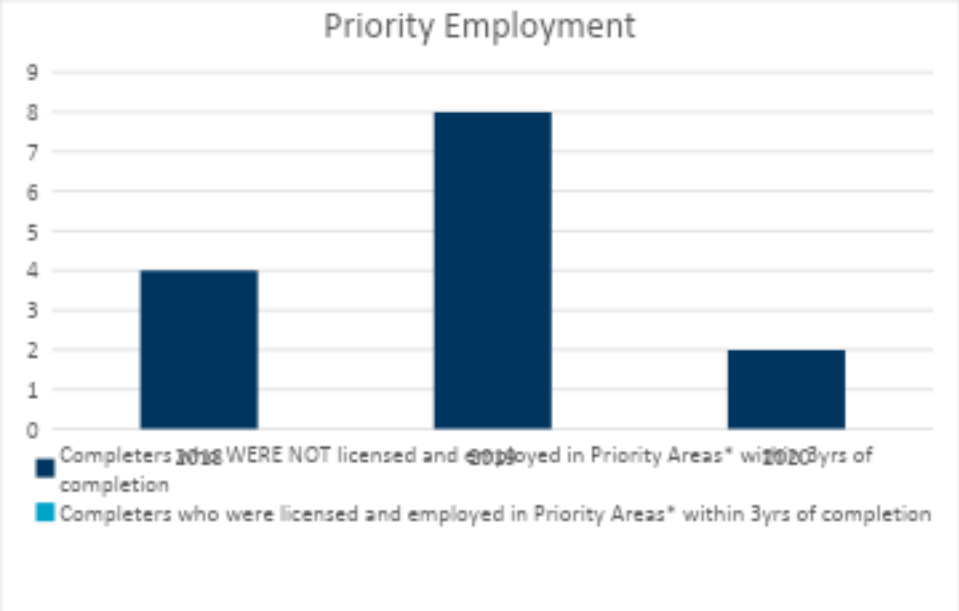
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in Arkansas public schools in their first three years after completion	64%	0%	BELOW



Criteria 3.2b

A high proportion of completers work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects

Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed Priority	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects in their first three years after completion	40%	0%	BELOW



*Priority Employment is employment in a high need subject area and/or geographical shortage area. Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline) and demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased) as well as state focus areas.

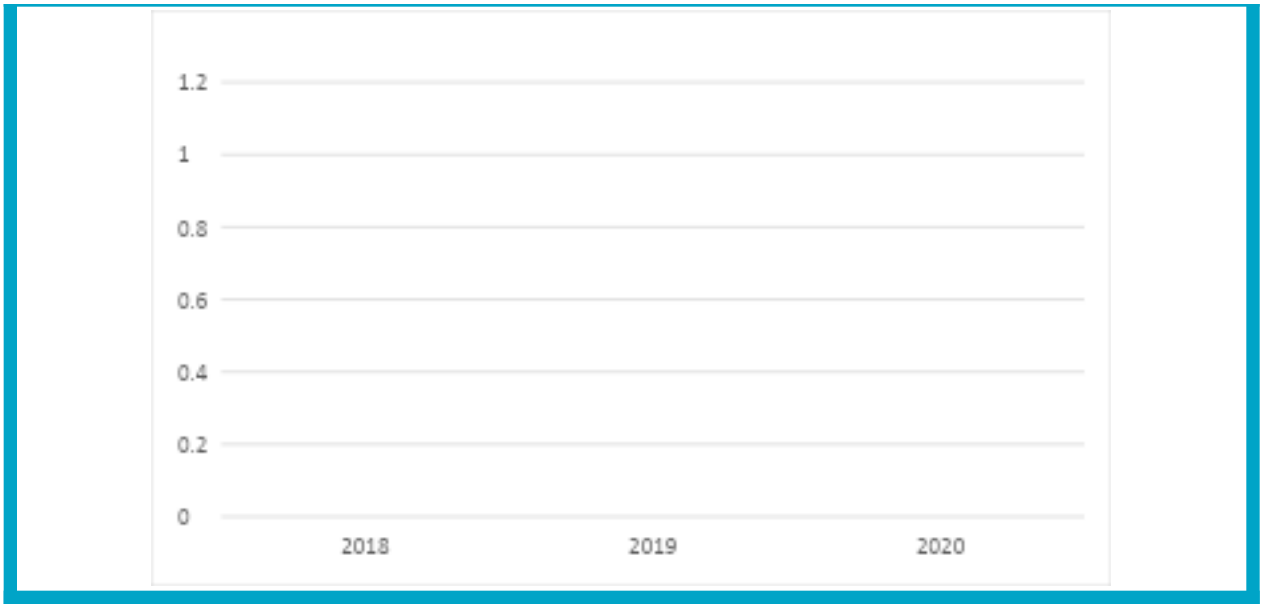
Current subject shortage areas for employment: Computer Science, Secondary Science, Foreign Language, Secondary Math, Middle School Math, Middle School Science, and Special Education.

Current geographical shortage areas are school districts located in the following co-op regions: Arkansas River ESC, Great Rivers ESC, Pulaski Co Schools, Southeast AR ESC.

Criteria 3.2c

Program completers remain in the classroom for multiple years

Metric	Target	EPP's Average Years of Experience, 3 Years After Completion	Performance Level
Program completers' average licensed teaching experience in Arkansas's public schools 3 years after completion	1.7	0	BELOW


1.2
1
0.8
0.6
0.4
0.2
0
2018
2019
2020

INDICATOR 3.3: EFFECTIVENESS

Criteria 3.3a

School leaders rate program completers that they hire as effective classroom teachers

Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ for each Domain	Performance Level
School leaders' perception of program completer effectiveness based on responses to the EPP Completer Supervisor Survey conducted annually by DESE	81%	50%	BELOW

Criteria 3.3b

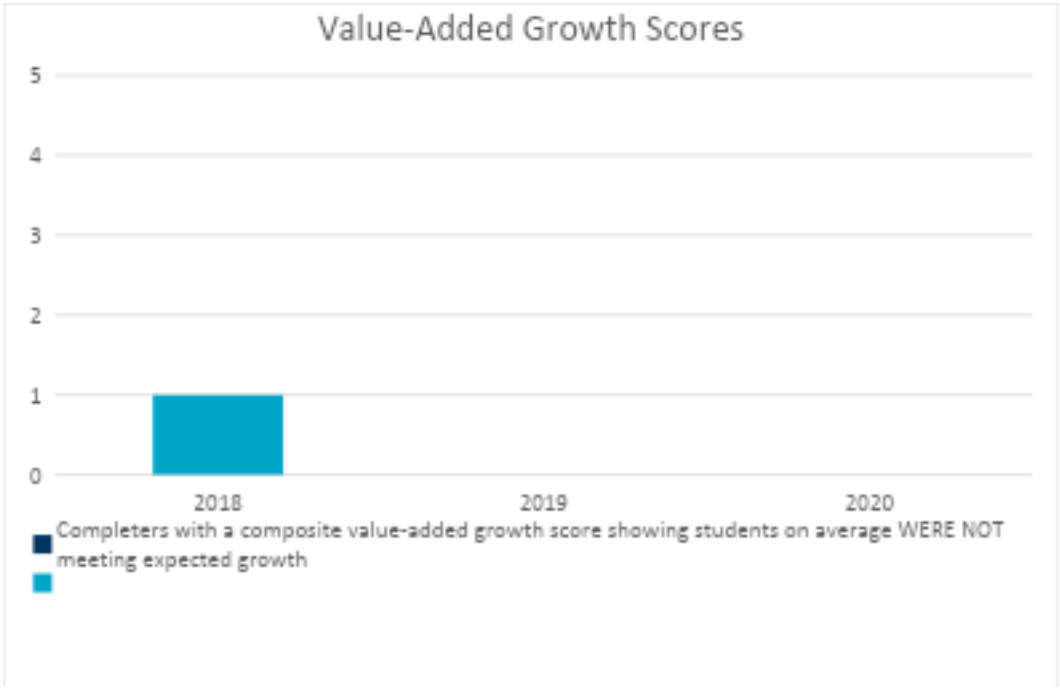
Completers feel that their program prepared them well to be a teacher

Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on each Domain	Performance Level
Program completers' perception of how well their program prepared them to be a teacher based on responses to the EPP Completer Survey conducted annually by DESE	75%	100%	EXCEEDS

Criteria 3.3c

A high proportion of program completers have above-average value-added scores

Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage with Average Value-Added of 80+	Performance Level
Percentage of program completers who have above-average value-added scores in their first three years after completion	43%	100%	EXCEEDS


Value-Added Growth Scores
5
4
3
2
1
0
2018
2019
2020
Completers with a composite value-added growth score showing students on average WERE NOT meeting expected growth